The Philosophical Roots of Loneliness and Intimacy

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Time-consciousness, Personal Identity and Loneliness

Perspectives from Literature on Time Consciousness: Thomas Wolfe and James Joyce

Language, Consciousness, and Loneliness

- Literature best expresses inner life: feelings, thoughts, meanings, and especially **loneliness**
- **Key tension:** words vs. consciousness
  - Words are static, separate, and artificial (like a dictionary)
  - Consciousness is fluid, temporal, nuanced, and alive
- There is always something **"lost in translation"** from thought to language
- Thoughts flow through time; words cannot fully capture **duration**, nuance, or lived experience
- Philosophers (Husserl, Bergson):
  - Consciousness is **primary and original**
  - Language is **secondary and derivative**
- Despite its limits, **literature remains the best medium** for teaching us about loneliness

Thomas Wolfe as a Novelist of Loneliness

- Wolfe is one of the greatest novelists of loneliness (alongside Hardy and Conrad)
- Loneliness in Wolfe:
  - Deeply personal and autobiographical
  - So intense it becomes **self-consuming and self-destructive**
- Wolfe views loneliness as:
  - **Universal**, not rare or exceptional
  - The **central fact of human existence**
- Everyday human conflict (anger, hatred, mistrust) is rooted in loneliness

Narrative Style and Autobiographical Works

- Influenced by **James Joyce's Ulysses** and its stream-of-consciousness technique
- Major works exploring loneliness:
  - *Look Homeward, Angel*
  - *Of Time and the River*
  - *You Can't Go Home Again*
  - *The Web and the Rock*
- Wolfe's introspection spirals inward, intensifying his isolation

Wolfe's Philosophy of Time

- Time is central to Wolfe's understanding of loneliness
- Two kinds of time:
  - **Public/objective time** (trains, rivers, clocks)
  - **Private/subjective time** (inner experience within the ego)
- This personal time is **"lonely time"**
- Influences:
  - **Kant:** time as the form of inner sense
  - **William James:** the "specious present"
  - **Bergson:** lived duration
- Temporal experience divided into:
  - Remembered past
  - Lived present
  - Anticipated future
- Time is rooted in experience but also structures experience

Loneliness as an Existential Condition

- Wolfe aligns with psychology and existential thought:
- Loneliness is universal and unavoidable
- Biblical parallel:
- **The Book of Job** symbolizes humanity's futile reaching for understanding and meaning
- Humans seek connection with others and with a higher being—often unsuccessfully

Literary Illustration: Night, Isolation, and Failed Communication

- Helen's nighttime reflection:
  - People everywhere are **alone together**, listening in silence
  - Momentary hope: shared loneliness could unite humanity
- This hope is quickly extinguished:
  - People cannot truly know one another
  - Speech often distorts rather than reveals truth
  - Communication increases misunderstanding
- Deeper reason:
  - We are **strangers to ourselves**
  - We cannot believe others are as lonely as we are

Insights

- Each person exists in **radical isolation**
- Loneliness is tied to **singular, temporal subjectivity**
- We live enclosed in our own time and consciousness
- **Loneliness = immanent time**
  - To exist in time is to exist alone

Raymond Tallis

Two Competing Theories of Time

- **Scientific / objective time**
  - Intersubjectively shared
  - Measured by motion of objects in space
  - Time = empirical change
- **Immanent / subjective time (idealism & phenomenology)**
- **Constituted by:**
    - Transcendental reflexive acts (Kant)
    - Intentional acts of consciousness (Husserl)
    - Time is inseparable from self-consciousness

Shift to Neuroscience and Intentionality

- The text critiques a **failed neuroscientific attempt** to explain:
  - Time
  - Unity of consciousness
  - Personal identity
- Focuses on Raymond Tallis' *Aping Mankind*
- Central claim: Tallis misuses **"intentionality"**, producing conceptual confusion

Tallis' Critique of Hume (and Its Failure)

- Tallis accepts Hume's view:
  - The self is a **fiction**
  - Consciousness is a bundle of fleeting perceptions
- Hume's famous claim:
  - No perception of a unified self, only successive impressions
- Tallis treats this as decisive

Kantian Counter-Argument (Missed by Tallis)

- Temporal succession **presupposes** a unified self
- One cannot be conscious of succession without:
  - A continuous, identical self synthesizing experiences
- Hume later **admits this paradox** in the Appendix to the *Treatise*
- Tallis fails to recognize Hume's own reconsideration

From Psychological Atomism to Neural Atomism

- Hume's "bundle of perceptions" parallels:
  - Neuroscience's "bundle of neurons"
- Both deny:
  - Intrinsic unity of consciousness
  - Reflexive self-awareness

Tallis' Misreading of Kant

- Tallis reduces Kant's:
  - Transcendental unity of apperception
  - To a Cartesian "I think"
- Criticizes Kant's claim:
  - "The 'I think' must be able to accompany all my representations"
- Misses Kant's key point:
  - Unity is **not empirical**
  - It is a **transcendental condition of experience**

Five Competing First Principles of Time

1. **Materialist scientific time**
   - Physical objects moving in space
2. **Humean atomistic succession**
   - Instantaneous impressions → paradox of temporal awareness
3. **Kantian transcendental unity**
   - Synthetic a priori conditions of time-consciousness
4. **Neuroscientific reductionism**
   - Causal chains of neuronal activity
5. **Tallis' appeal to intentionality (Brentano)**
   - Inconsistently imports idealist assumptions

Tallis on Intentionality

- Claims intentionality explains:
  - Subjectivity
  - Self-consciousness
  - Freedom
  - Human world-making
- But:
  - Intentionality is **non-material**
  - Its use contradicts Tallis' neuroscientific commitments
- He criticizes reductionism while quietly adopting phenomenological premises

The Problem of Qualia

- Tallis:
- Accepts the brain as physical
- Treats qualia as mysterious, irreducible
- Claims:
  - Qualia are not neural
  - But somehow generate time, unity, freedom, selfhood
- This creates an unresolved gap between:
  - Physical neurons
  - Immaterial experience

Dualism in Disguise

- Tallis posits:
  - A “non-physical human world”
  - Objects that transcend perception
  - A self distinct from the world
- This resembles:
  - Metaphysical dualism
  - Subjective idealism
- Yet Tallis insists on empirical respectability
- Result: **“Having your metaphysical cake and eating it”**

Time, Memory, and the Self

- Tallis treats time as:
  - External events stored in memory (Lockean view)
- Unity over time explained via:
  - Brain “localizations”
  - Neural scheduling
- But neural complexity:
  - Does not explain immanent temporal self-consciousness

Freedom and Responsibility

- Tallis rejects strict determinism
- Introduces human freedom without explanation
- Freedom is:
  - Not quantum indeterminacy
  - Not grounded in a clear metaphysical account
- Selfhood becomes:
- Vague
  - Ad hoc
  - “Mysterious”

Bergson and Memory

- Tallis criticizes Bergson's idea of memory as a "cerebral deposit"
- But Tallis repeats Bergson's error:
  - Trying to reconcile material brain with immaterial time-consciousness
- Bergson's real contribution:
  - *Time and Free Will*
  - Lived duration and qualitative experience

Neglect of Phenomenology

- Tallis invokes intentionality but:
  - Ignores Husserl
  - Misreads Brentano
- For Brentano:
  - Consciousness is **active**
  - Intentionality is purposive and teleological
- Brains are:
  - Reactive mechanisms
  - Not active thinking substances

Critical Conclusion

- Neuroscience alone cannot explain:
  - Immanent time-consciousness
  - Unity of self
  - Reflexive awareness
- Tallis critiques reductionism but:
  - Lacks a coherent alternative
  - Smuggles in idealism without acknowledging it
- Genuine intentionality requires:
  - A return to Kant, Brentano, and Husserl
  - Recognition of synthetic a priori unity of consciousness

Brentano, James and Bailey

Aristotle: Empiricism and Dualism

- Empiricist:
  - Soul as **tabula rasa** (blank tablet)
- Dualist:
- Immaterial intellect (Unmoved Mover analogy)
  - Thought unifies subject and object
- Brentano inherits both:
  - Aristotelian conceptualism
  - Metaphysical dualism
- Brentano's religious commitments:
  - Immortality of the soul
  - Active substance of consciousness

William James and Temporal Succession

- James' key insight:
  - **A succession of feelings ≠ a feeling of succession**
- Physical states (neurons, pebbles):
  - Do not carry temporal meaning
  - Require an observing consciousness
- Neuroscience fails by:
  - "Smuggling in" consciousness
  - Treating synapses as self-sufficient sources of temporality

Kant versus James on Time

- Kant:
  - Temporality is the essence of **reflexive self-consciousness**
  - Time is a condition of personal identity
  - Relations are **thought**, not felt
- James:
  - Grounds consciousness in the brain and introspection
  - Proposes a “stream of consciousness”
  - Rejects a substantial or transcendental self
- Result:
  - James’ view lacks a coherent account of personal identity

James' Radical Empiricism

- Philosophy must:
  - Ground relations in **immediate experience**
  - Avoid Kantian and Hegelian metaphysics
- Claims:
  - Conjunctive relations are immediately felt
  - Continuity is directly experienced
- Problem:
  - Reduces relations to feelings
  - Collapses mediation into immediacy

Five Characteristics of James' Stream of Thought

1. Thought belongs to a **personal consciousness**
2. Thought is constantly **changing**
3. Thought is **continuous**
4. Thought is directed toward **independent objects**
5. Thought is **selective and interested**

Personal Identity in James

- Grounded in:
  - Bodily warmth
  - Sensory intimacy
- Identity formed by:
  - Assimilation of “warm” experiences
- Critique:
  - Reduces selfhood to bodily feeling
  - Undermines enduring personal identity

James' Critique of Kant

- Rejects:
  - Transcendental Ego
  - Unity of apperception
- Accepts only:
  - Empirical continuity of thoughts
- Irony:
  - James' own descriptions rely on reflexive self-awareness
  - Uses Kantian language while denying Kantian foundations

Metaphors of Consciousness (James)

- **Bird metaphor**:
  - Flights = transitive parts (relations)
  - Perchings = substantive parts (sensory contents)
- **Stream metaphor**:
  - Consciousness as flowing flux
- Critique:
  - Misrepresents activity as rest
  - Confuses spatial imagery with temporal relations

Relations, Activity, and Temporality

- Idealist view:
  - Relations are **active and synthetic**
  - Temporal consciousness is always active
- James' failure:
  - Treats relations as bodily or sensory
  - Neglects mediation and synthesis

Bailey's Neuroscientific Revision

- Rejects "stream" metaphor
- Proposes:
  - Consciousness as **embedded transitions**
  - Thoughts as a causal chain
- Problem:
  - Still lacks genuine relations
  - Reduces mediation to physical succession

Neuroscience vs. Phenomenology

- Neuroscience:
  - Deals with discrete neurons and synapses
  - Eliminates conjunctive relations
- Phenomenology:
  - Centers on immanent time-consciousness
  - Requires synthesis and spontaneity
- Reductionism erases:
  - Subject–object relations
  - Temporal mediation
  - Personal identity

Critical Claims

- James, Hume, and neuroscience:
  - Reduce mediate relations to immediate feelings
  - Eliminate genuine temporality
- Idealism (Kant, Husserl, Hegel):
  - Preserves synthesis, mediation, and unity
- Without synthetic activity:
  - No time-consciousness
  - No personal identity
  - No genuine intentionality

Thinker / Framework	Nature of Time	Consciousness	Personal Identity	Role of Relations	Core Problem / Critique
Scientific / Materialist Time	Objective, public, measurable; time = motion of objects in space	Product of physical processes	Grounded in bodily continuity (DNA, brain, behavior)	External, causal relations only	Cannot explain immanent time or felt succession
Hume (Empirical Atomism)	Succession of discrete impressions	Bundle of perceptions; no intrinsic unity	A fiction produced by memory and habit	Reduced to psychological association	Admits succession but cannot explain unity of awareness
Kant (Transcendental Idealism)	Immanent time as form of inner sense	Reflexive self-consciousness; synthetic a priori unity	Grounded in unity of apperception	Relations are *thought*, not felt	Rejected by empiricists as "metaphysical"
Aristotle (Conceptualism / Dualism)	Time tied to change, but intellect is timeless	Soul as active principle	Unified by intellect (nous)	Conceptual mediation between subject & object	Tension between empiricism and immaterial intellect
Brentano (Intentionality)	Presupposed by conscious acts	Every act is self-conscious	Unity via active mental acts	Intentional, purposive, teleological	Incompatible with reductive neuroscience
William James (Radical Empiricism)	Lived succession within the "stream of consciousness"	Brain-based, introspective	Grounded in bodily warmth & continuity of thoughts	Relations are immediately *felt*	Reduces mediation to immediacy
James (Neutral Monism)	Neither mental nor physical	Consciousness as a function, not a substance	No substantial self	Relations collapse into experience	Undermines enduring identity
Neuroscience (Reductionism)	External time mapped onto neural events	Electrical synapses and brain states	Functional or behavioral continuity	Eliminated or reduced to causation	Cannot account for reflexive awareness
Tallis (Aping Mankind)	External objective time + memory	Brain-based but qualia-rich	Enduring moral and social self	Appeals to "intentionality"	Smuggles in idealism while denying it
Husserl (Phenomenology)	Immanent time-consciousness (retention/protention)	Active, reflexive consciousness	Unified through temporal synthesis	Constitutive relations	Ignored or misunderstood by Tallis
Hegel (Objective Idealism)	Time as expression of Spirit	Consciousness = qualitative reality	Identity via dialectical development	Mediated, conceptual relations	Rejected as "metaphysical fiction"

- **Succession ≠ temporal consciousness** (Hume, James, neuroscience fail here)
- **Relations require synthesis**, not just sensation (Kant, Husserl)
- **Intentionality is active**, not neural (Brentano vs neuroscience)
- **Neuroscience explains events, not unity**
- **Tallis critiques reductionism but lacks a coherent alternative**